

TEACHER PROFESSIONAL LEARNING NOTES

Background Reading & Professional Development Guidance | All Year Levels

Research base for water safety education.
Teacher content knowledge — key concepts.
First aid currency requirements and PL pathways.

■ The Evidence Base — Why This Unit Matters

Key finding: Drowning is preventable.

The evidence is clear that water safety education, when delivered well and connected to real-world application, saves lives. You are not teaching a compliance exercise — you are delivering content with direct life-or-death relevance.

54	Victorian drowning deaths in 2023-24 — highest in over a decade
85%	of Victorian drowning deaths in 2023-24 were male
40%	of Victorian drowning deaths involved CALD community members (~28% of population)
0	drowning deaths at patrolled locations in 2023-24
~320,000	global drowning deaths annually (WHO) — 90% in low/middle-income countries
4 min	bystander CPR window before significant irreversible brain damage

■ Teacher Content Knowledge — Key Concepts

What every teacher delivering this unit should know fluently:

- The 5 SwimSafe rules — Read signs; Feet first; Stay in depth; Swim with friend; Signal for help
- Beach flag system — Red/yellow (safe zone), single red (danger), orange windsock (no inflatables), purple (marine danger)
- DRS ABCD in order — Danger, Response, Send (000), Airway, Breathing, CPR, Defibrillation
- CPR ratio and rate — 30:2; rate 100-120 bpm; depth 5-6cm; allow full chest recoil
- Rip current escape — Float; stay calm; swim PARALLEL to shore; angle back when clear; raise one arm
- Throw, Don't Go — Never enter water to rescue unless trained. Throw first.
- 4-minute CPR window — brain cells begin dying irreversibly after 4-6 minutes without oxygenated blood

■ Common student misconceptions to address proactively:

- "If you can swim, you're safe" — false. Most Victorian drowning victims could swim.
- "The water looks calm, so it's safe" — false. Rip currents and cold water shock are invisible.
- "Swim hard against a rip to get back" — dangerous. This causes exhaustion and drowning.
- "Someone else will call 000" — the bystander effect. Direct, named instruction is essential.
- "I've jumped there before, it's safe" — false confidence. Depth changes with every tide, flood, and season.
- "Good swimmers are safe from diving injuries" — false. Cervical spine fracture on impact is unrelated to swim ability.

■ Diving & Spinal Injury — Key Content for Year 9-10 Teachers:

- 10% of all spinal cord injuries and 20% of quadriplegia cases in Australia are caused by unsafe diving (AIHW)
- 95% of patients are male; 75%+ are under 30; highest incidence age group: 10-14 years; 66% suffer permanent disability
- Cervical spine (C1-C7) fracture or dislocation on impact can instantly sever the spinal cord — causing permanent quadriplegia. Spinal cord neurons do not regenerate.
- Three 2024-25 case studies: Terrigal Wharf NSW (wharf depth unknown), Torquay Front Beach Vic (shifting sandbank), Bawley Beach NSW (sandbank formed between visits — false confidence)
- Core prevention message: "Feet First, First Time" — always enter unknown water feet-first; check depth every visit regardless of prior experience
- Inland waterways are the highest-risk aquatic environment in Australia (RLSSA). Five risk factors: changing depth, poor visibility, cold water shock, alcohol/group risk-taking, remote rescue delay
- Post-COVID: 15-20 year old drowning rate increased 34% compared to pre-COVID period (RLSSA)

■ First Aid Currency Requirements

Activity	Required certification	Renewal
Classroom water safety theory lessons	No formal first aid requirement — standard teacher training applies	—
School swimming carnival (supervisor)	Current first aid certificate (HLTAID011 or equivalent). At least one qualified first aider on site.	3 years
Pool-based practical sessions	Current first aid certificate. Check school policy — some require a lifeguard present.	3 years
Water-based excursion (off-site)	Current first aid certificate. DE Excursion Policy and Swimming Policy requirements apply. See Excursion Risk Management Template.	3 years

■ Renewal tip:

St John Ambulance Victoria and Australian Red Cross both offer low-cost first aid renewal courses, including online theory components. Book at stjohnvic.com.au or redcross.org.au/first-aid.

■ Professional Learning Pathways

Program	What it covers	URL
LSV Teacher PD	Professional development for HPE teachers — water safety, beach safety, aquatic supervision. Free or low-cost.	lsv.com.au/education
AUSTSWIM Qualifications	Nationally recognised qualifications including Teacher of Swimming and Water Safety (TSWS). Directly supports VCHPEM146 and VCHPEM162 delivery.	austswim.com.au
RLSSA Research & Resources	Annual National Drowning Report and evidence briefs. Free school education resources.	royallifesaving.com.au/research
First Aid Currency	Maintain HLTAID011 (Provide First Aid). Annual CPR refresher (HLTAID009) strongly recommended for pool sessions.	stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-courses/

Program	What it covers	URL
LSV Multicultural Safety PL	Professional learning for culturally responsive water safety education — valuable for high CALD-enrolment schools.	lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/
First Nations Cultural Competency	Reconciliation Australia online cultural learning resources and AIATSIS for embedding First Nations perspectives into HPE.	reconciliation.org.au/schools/